

HOLDING COURT
(From left) Aditi Rao Hydari, Pratibha Ranta, Manisha Koirala, Sanjeeda Shaikh and Richa Chadha in *Heeramandi;* *(inset) Sanjay Leela Bhansali*

Photographs: NETFLIX

An opulent, expensive passion project, or Sanjay Leela Bhansali's gift to the world? Viewers can't wait to find out as *Heeramandi*, his paean to six courtesans in the Lahore of pre-Independence days, drops on Netflix

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By SUHANI SINGH

At the launch of the trailer for *Heeramandi: The Diamond Bazaar*, which Netflix has billed as "India's biggest cinematic series", the international streaming giant pulled out all the stops to promote one of 2024's most anticipated shows—and also Netflix India's most expensive outing till date (made at a rumoured budget of Rs 200 crore)—giving a sneak peek into the world its creator Sanjay Leela Bhansali (SLB) has conjured. The event, held at the Taj Palace Hotel in New Delhi in early April, saw the main conference hall at the hotel being converted into a *bazaar*, with stalls offering *gajras* (garlands made of mogra flowers) and *attar* (perfume). In one corner, two women dressed in *rani* pink (hot pink) ensembles helped attendees pick Urdu poetry to send to a lover or a dear friend; another corner had an exhibit displaying the embellished costumes designers Rimple and Harpreet Narula have created for the show's six leading ladies. Bhansali himself was missing, but the rich cast—Manisha Koirala, Sonakshi Sinha, Richa Chadha, Aditi Rao Hydari, Sharmin Segal, Sanjeeda Shaikh, Shekhar Suman and Fardeen Khan among them—along with Netflix India VP Monika Shergill and Bhansali Productions CEO Prerna Singh, waxed eloquent about him enough to remind everyone that the court belonged to one man and one man alone.

Four years in the making, the eight-episode series about the life of six courtesans in the backdrop of India's freedom struggle dropped on the OTT